Corrector

By Maximillian Gill

CHARACTERS

- *REFUGEE -- any age, any gender, any ethnicity, refugee from a war-torn nation.*
- *CORRECTOR -- any age, any gender, any ethnicity, helps refugees for a price.*

***SETTING** -- A basement in a border town in an unnamed country.*

***TIME** -- An indeterminate point in the future.*

Although the play is inspired by the current refugee crisis, it is intended to represent dislocation and assimilation as universal human experiences; thus, nationalities are not specified. However, the characters should represent two ethnicities or should at least read as "different." The Refugee should ideally speak with some sort of accent and be a bit hesitant with language that is not their mother tongue. The neutral pronoun is used throughout for convenience.

INTRODUCTION

ACTOR 1: *Refugee -- by definition a person who has fled their home, crossed an international border and cannot return to their home country because they fear their life is in danger.*
ACTOR 2: *In the US, this concept is difficult to fathom. I mean, we've heard the word, but is it likely that John Smith from (Insert City, State) will ever experience life as a refugee?*
ACTOR 1: *What if I told you that world-wide as of October 2023 (update as needed), there are over 36.4 million refugees.**
ACTOR 2: *And with new refugee crises in Ukraine and Gaza capturing headlines, the plight of others are at risk of being forgotten: Myanmar's Rohingya, refugees of the Syrian Civil War, Afghans who fled the Taliban takeover. The list goes on . . .*
ACTOR 1: *Poet Warsan Shire perhaps said it best: "No one leaves home unless home is the mouth of a shark."*
ACTOR 2: *What personal sacrifices are made by refugees in exchange for just the possibility of safety? What would you be willing to sacrifice?*
TOGETHER: *Corrector by Maximillian Gill*

(Pg 77-84) *A basement. Midnight. CORRECTOR paces, checks their phone. Knock on door. They tap a button on the phone and put it in a pocket. They go to the door. REFUGEE enters, agitated*

CORRECTOR: Anybody follow you?

REFUGEE: I don't like this place.

CORRECTOR: Then leave.

REFUGEE: You be careful with me.

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CORRECTOR: I need to? *(REFUGEE circles CORRECTOR menacingly)*

REFUGEE: You know my country.

CORRECTOR: I know your nation is in the midst of a civil war of apocalyptic proportions.

REFUGEE: I was a soldier in that war.

CORRECTOR: Did you commit any atrocities I should know about?

REFUGEE: I won't talk about it.

CORRECTOR: Based on what we're told, your countrymen are a dangerous and violent menace who will likely destroy themselves.

REFUGEE: *(They bristle at this a bit before answering)* Yes, that's me.

CORRECTOR: Then I do need to be careful.

REFUGEE: It is true you don't want money?

CORRECTOR: Where did you hear that?

REFUGEE: At the camp.

CORRECTOR: And you believe it?

REFUGEE: It is true?

CORRECTOR: If it is, shouldn't there be a long line of refugees outside my door? *(REFUGEE goes to the exit)* Wait.

REFUGEE: *(REFUGEE stops)* Just to get here, I used all my money.

CORRECTOR: You need to know what I'm offering.

REFUGEE: You'll take me over the border.

CORRECTOR: Where do you think you want to go?

REFUGEE: The country on the other side.

CORRECTOR: You can pay quite a bit to get across. But once there you'll just end up in another camp.

REFUGEE: What else can I do?

CORRECTOR: You can stay here.

REFUGEE: I have no papers.

CORRECTOR: Papers can be arranged.

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REFUGEE: People from my country cannot have papers.

CORRECTOR: You can be here, fully legal, with papers, with a job, in a safe part of the country.

REFUGEE: I am not allowed any of that here.

CORRECTOR: Why?

REFUGEE: They know where I am from.

CORRECTOR: What if nobody could tell?

REFUGEE: How?

CORRECTOR: What marks you?

REFUGEE: I don't understand. *(CORRECTOR grabs REFUGEE arm)*

CORRECTOR: This skin color? Is that it? *(REFUGEE removes CORRECTOR'S hand violently)* Is it your voice, your manner of walking? The way you move your head in such a way that I can't tell whether you're nodding or shaking it?

REFUGEE: It is everything.

CORRECTOR: I'm a corrector. I correct people.

REFUGEE: I am not wrong.

CORRECTOR: You are if you want to be here.

REFUGEE: Explain.

CORRECTOR: A form of gene therapy. Chemical injections. They'll correct you.

REFUGEE: And then what?

CORRECTOR: They'll change your skin color and subtly alter your facial features so you'll look more like us.

REFUGEE: All on the outside.

CORRECTOR: No, inside too. After genetic modification we proceed with a regimen to adjust your brain chemistry.

REFUGEE: What does it do?

CORRECTOR: Soften your accent. Give you a better command of our language. You'll even think like we do.

REFUGEE: Is it legal?

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CORRECTOR: Not even close. But it's effective.

REFUGEE: I'll be like you.

CORRECTOR: It's not reversible. Who you are now, you won't be that ever again.

REFUGEE: To be here, I can't be who I am.

CORRECTOR: No, listen to me, you'll forget.

REFUGEE: What?

CORRECTOR: It's a side effect of the procedure. Slowly but methodically you will forget. Your mother tongue, the smells of your own country, the way the air feels on a summer morning.

REFUGEE: Forget those things?

CORRECTOR: The person you are now will be gone. But you will fit in very well.

REFUGEE: No.

CORRECTOR: It's the only way.

REFUGEE: I won't be who I am anymore.

CORRECTOR: Now you know why there's no line outside my door.

REFUGEE: I can't forget everything.

CORRECTOR: You've already left it behind.

REFUGEE: Because I had to.

CORRECTOR: Obviously you have another option.

REFUGEE: Which?

CORRECTOR: You can simply go back where you came from.

REFUGEE: The war will kill everybody.

CORRECTOR: You decide.

REFUGEE: When?

CORRECTOR: I administer the protocol in my workroom. It'll take all night. The recovery period will be long, but you will soon feel different.

REFUGEE: I can't lose who I am.

CORRECTOR: What's so great that you can't lose it?

REFUGEE: To me it's everything.

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CORRECTOR: What exactly?

REFUGEE: I won't tell you.

CORRECTOR: Prove it.

REFUGEE: You will never have to hide who you are. You will never have to speak your own language only in a whisper or have some name that is not yours.

CORRECTOR: The way this world is going. Let's not be so sure.

REFUGEE: It is not the same for you.

CORRECTOR: What are you most afraid of losing?

REFUGEE: I don't want to lose anything.

CORRECTOR: But right now, choose something.

REFUGEE: It is all something to me.

CORRECTOR: At this moment, what is a painful thing for you to forget?

REFUGEE: A song.

CORRECTOR: What kind of song?

REFUGEE: A song kind of song. A song of my people. My mother sang to me when I was very little.

CORRECTOR: Sing it for me.

REFUGEE: People laugh at our music. It is ugly to them.

CORRECTOR: But it's important to you. Show me that it is.

REFUGEE: I can't remember the words.

CORRECTOR: Just sing.

(REFUGEE starts to sing a tune without words. They stop for a moment, embarrassed, and then continue. CORRECTOR listens, eyes closed. REFUGEE stops. CORRECTOR takes a phone out and presses a button.)

REFUGEE: What did you do?

CORRECTOR: I recorded you.

REFUGEE: What is this?

CORRECTOR: Just relax.

REFUGEE: You will turn me in.

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CORRECTOR: No.

REFUGEE: Give me the phone.

CORRECTOR: *(CORRECTOR puts it away and backs off)* Let me explain.

(REFUGEE takes out a knife and attacks CORRECTOR. They scuffle. REFUGEE is not a good fighter. CORRECTOR disarms them and gets them on the ground. CORRECTOR holds up the knife.)

CORRECTOR: A soldier would be better with this. But you weren't a soldier, were you?

REFUGEE: *(REFUGEE stands up)* I made bread. In a bread shop.

CORRECTOR: I assume you've never killed anybody.

REFUGEE: You could be my first.

CORRECTOR: Clever tactic, using a violent stereotype as a defense mechanism. *(CORRECTOR takes out the phone)* Now listen. *(REFUGEE grabs the phone from CORRECTOR'S hand. REFUGEE holds it as if ready to smash it against the wall.)* No, don't.

REFUGEE: Tell me why or I break it.

CORRECTOR: I have a lot of voices in there. Some people give me recipes for delicately spiced dishes they used to cook in their home country. Others tell me stories they first learned from their grandmothers. A few videos demonstrate dances. One man told me five words in your language that have no equivalent in mine. My favorite is one that describes that specific pang of regret when one recognizes that something lost can never be recovered. From you, I have a song.

REFUGEE: I don't understand.

CORRECTOR: It's true, you will forget who you are. But you will not be forgotten. I'll keep you here.

REFUGEE: Why?

CORRECTOR: I'm a corrector. Because something in this world is very wrong. *(REFUGEE hands the phone back to CORRECTOR.)* This is all I wanted from you. You've paid. Do you want what you paid for?

REFUGEE: After I forget, can I come back here and listen to my song?

CORRECTOR: I hope you will. *(REFUGEE makes an ambiguous motion of the head.)*

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CORRECTOR: I still can't tell if that's a "yes" or a "no."

REFUGEE: It has to be "yes."

SOURCE INFORMATION

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**** Source for Introduction Statistic***
UNHCR – The UN Refugee Agency
https://www.unhcr.org/refugee-statistics/

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